The Flow Health Check

Ten checks that reveal whether your board is telling the truth. Tick what is true today, not what the process document says. Run it with the whole team in fifteen minutes, then discuss the gaps. Companion to my case study, When the board and the work disagree.

Waiting Disguised as Working

- [ ] Wait states are visible. Blocked and waiting work is tagged or has its own lane, it does not sit in "In progress" looking busy.
  Ask: pick any in-progress ticket. What happened on it yesterday? If the honest answer is "waited", it wasn't in progress.

- [ ] We know our flow efficiency, even roughly. We can say what share of cycle time is active work versus waiting.
  Ask: is the number under 40 per cent? For most teams it is. That is normal, and it is also the biggest lever you have.

- [ ] Dependencies on other teams are visible on our board, not just in someone's head or a Slack thread.

Work That Never Boards

- [ ] Production support, incidents and "quick favours" go on the board, however small.
  Ask: what did each person do this week that appears nowhere? That is your invisible capacity leak.

- [ ] The board reflects true capacity. Nobody is secretly on two boards, half-allocated or covering a vacancy unknown to the board.

- [ ] WIP limits exist, are visible and stopped something recently. A limit that has never been hit is a decoration.

Columns Describing Hand-Offs, Not Value

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- [ ] Columns describe progress towards customer value, not our org chart. "Dev, Code review, QA, Deploy" is a diagram of hand-offs, and every boundary is a queue.

- [ ] Done means in customers' hands, or the column says what it really means.
  Ask: how many "done" items from last month have no customer using them yet?

- [ ] Cycle time is measured from commitment to customer, not from "picked up" to "merged".

- [ ] The board starts arguments. Someone was made usefully uncomfortable by it in the last month. A board that never embarrasses anyone is decorative.

Scoring, loosely: 8 to 10 ticks, your board and reality mostly agree, manage the trend. 5 to 7, pick the two unticked boxes that hurt most and fix only those this quarter. 0 to 4, stop tuning ceremonies, your board is fiction, start by boarding everything and tagging the waiting.

> **How I use this:** not as an audit. I run it with the team, ticks are agreed together, and the disagreements about whether a box deserves a tick are worth more than the score. Repeat quarterly, chase the trend, ignore the absolute number.

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